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Have you used Artificial Intelligence (AI) in any part of this assignment?	No
If you have ticked "Yes" above, please briefly outline below which AI tool you have used, and what you have used it for. Please note, you must also reference the use of generative AI correctly within your assessment, in line with the guidance provided in your student handbook.	

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ByteBite: A Critical Evaluation of a Student-Focused Digital Marketing Strategy

1. Introduction

ByteBite is a Food Tech startup which offers 15-minute pre-portioned meal kits aimed at university students and fresh graduates aged 18 to 25 years living independently in UK cities. The meal kits cost from £4.99 each and seek to address the void between the high-end meal kits companies like HelloFresh which target family-oriented households and the perceived economy of repeated takeaway orders. ByteBite's brand identity employs two of the archetypes, namely the Everyman, indicating inclusion and friendliness, and the Jester, indicating fun and pleasure. Mark & Pearson (2001) explain that combining adjacent archetypes leads to more robust brand personality than individual archetypes, an idea which ByteBite exploits effectively in its website, blog, and Instagram ads. Furthermore, narrowing the gap between brand identity and brand reputation is considered a key driver of long-term brand loyalty (de Chernatony, 1999).

Retention, and not acquisition, is the main marketing issue. ByteBite creates first-order conversions via its introductory offer of £1.99, but its unit economics become sustainable after six or more repeat purchases by each customer. The analysis of the proposed marketing strategy reveals four key factors driving the attrition rate: limited development of cooking habits, lack of structured post-purchase communication, insufficient community involvement, and strong pull of existing takeaway routines. They are interlinked. Dealing with any of them in isolation is not enough unless the strategy works as a coherent mechanism of content, communication, and community.

This paper assesses the digital marketing strategy of the group across three key areas: Content Marketing Strategy, Marketing Communications Plan, and Critical Reflection with Recommendations.

2. Content Marketing Strategy

2.1. Value Proposition and SEO

The online value proposition of ByteBite relates to three out of the six Cs of the model explained: Cost Reduction (saving £4.99 instead of £12-16 with Deliveroo), Convenience (15-minute preparation), Community (recipe sharing among peers through WhatsApp). All these aspects are conveyed right away, above the fold, thus following the principle of progressive disclosure. In light of the Woodall's (2003) approach to the analysis of the five aspects of value, the vulnerability of this proposition structure is obvious: ByteBite initially competes through Sale VC by offering students a low-cost, low-sacrifice first purchase. However, supermarket meal deals provide a similarly affordable alternative with even less commitment. ByteBite must therefore create Derived VC through cooking confidence, habit formation and community, making the brand valuable beyond price. This provides the theoretical justification for the proposed community and gamification features.

The SEO strategy places emphasis on four of the six categories of SEO techniques: on-page, technical, local, and AI-powered (GEO). But in the three stages of Google ranking, namely, crawling, indexing, and serving, the failure lies in the second step since the self-rated SEO score is 28/100. Inability of a website to be successfully indexed makes it impossible to have any organic visitors from blog posts since technical SEO needs to be done first before any content can work. Through keyword research using Answer the Public, we had the informational keywords cluster appropriate for the Discover phase of the Customer Value Journey, but skewed toward readers rather than buyers. An alternative strategy would have been a short video on TikTok, where visibility is driven by algorithmic amplification rather than search engine indexing. However, a blog-led approach is better aligned with ByteBite's objective of building a searchable, long-term brand presence through SEO and valuable content. Its success, however, ultimately depends on resolving the website's technical SEO and performance limitations to maximise discoverability and conversion.

2.2. Story-telling, Persuasion, and the Blog Posts

Blog Posts - The Sunday Plan That Never Happens, The Supermarket Spiral, The Deadline Diet, The Group Chat Dinner, The Takeaway Trap, and The 15-Minute Dinner Fix constitute the most evolved form of output under the strategy. The criteria for developing brand stories that would be able to create a successful brand story have been established as making the customer the hero and resolving through brand relevance rather than promotion. Altogether, the above posts can be said to include two out of the five categories of brand stories, namely the functional category by positioning ByteBite with speed and low cost, and lifestyle story category by associating cooking with being an independent student. An Underdog narrative

was not utilised, although it could have strengthened ByteBite's challenger positioning and emotional appeal.

The blog series also applies Cialdini's principles of influence (1984), using empathy, scarcity, authority, unity, liking and consistency to lower psychological resistance and encourage engagement. This method of persuasion is successful since it is in line with the peripheral route of the Elaboration Likelihood Model where attitudes are formed through emotional appeal rather than argumentation (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986). For those students who are in the consider phase of the Customer Value Journey and are trying to compare ByteBite with other products, the central route post about verified cooking times, costs or nutrition facts can make the blog series more convincing at the conversion phase.

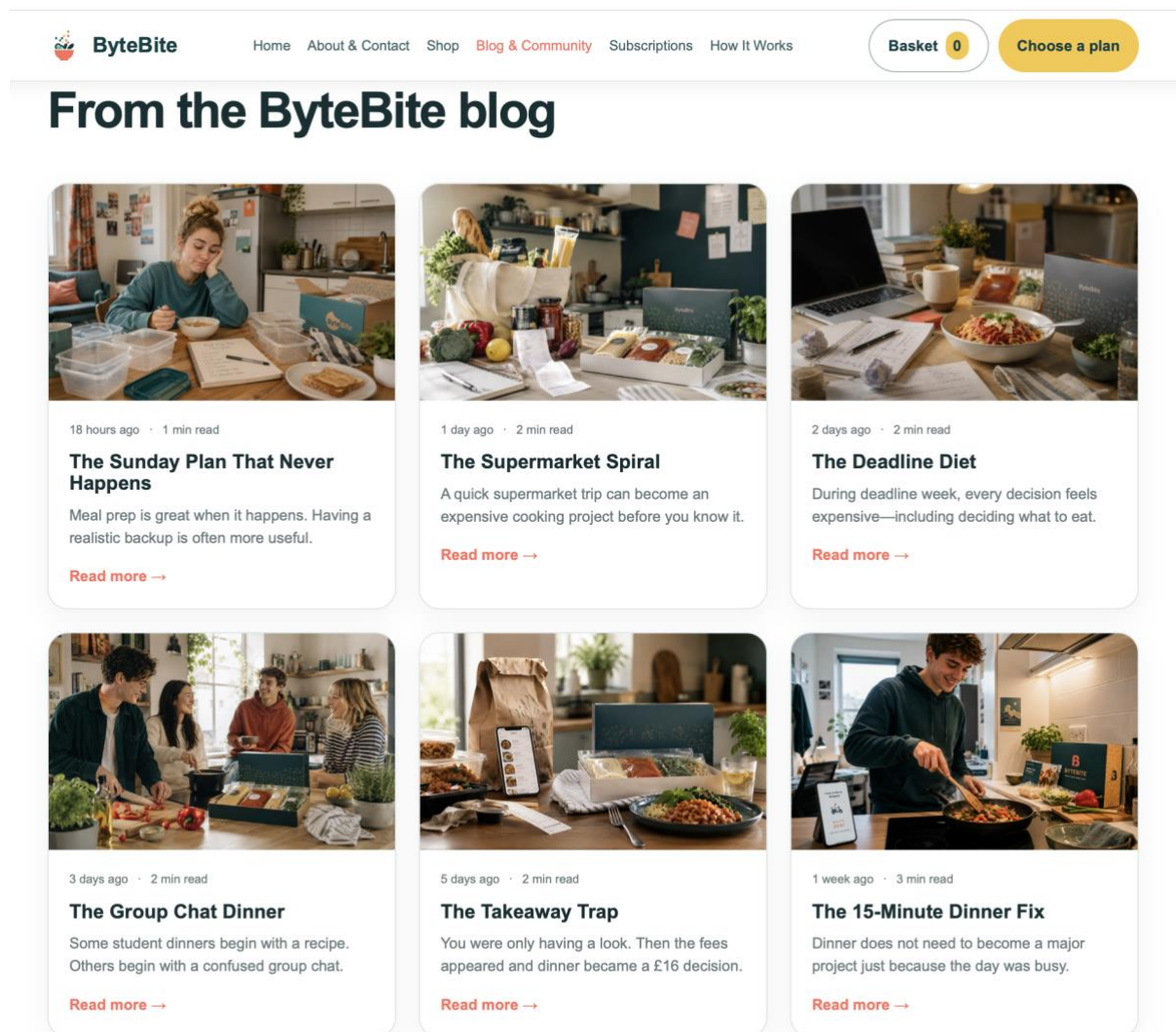


Figure 1: Website Blog Posts

2.3. Gamification

Gamification through points, badges, leaderboards, and challenges is one of the forces behind purchase intent, brand loyalty, and word-of-mouth (Hollebeek et al., 2019). The badge of cooking streak and challenges for recipes together with a leaderboard for referrals by ByteBite align with these gamification techniques and aim at addressing the weak Retain and Advocate phases of the Customer Value Journey. These aspects are still only goals, as without a working post-purchase communication tool, gamification would not work as a retention technique.

3. Marketing Communication Plan

3.1. Target Audience and Segmentation

The group's segmentation combines demographic (aged 18–25), behavioural (cooking infrequently, spending regularly on takeaway), and psychographic (budget-conscious but convenience-oriented, socially active) dimensions. In addition, the 4S profile of the consumer behaviour, "always streaming, scrolling, searching and shopping", proves that paid social media advertising should be used over Google PPC as the audience does not actively look for the product, therefore, the brand will have to catch their attention while scrolling. The main persona is Alex, a 20-year-old student from Birmingham who needs to budget £80-100 for food per week between studying, part-time work and sport activities. It is important because the issue for him is the lack of time to cook, not the lack of money, and thus the key message "time-removal" leads to habit formation much better than money-removal which brings only occasional customers.

An important constraint is that of homogeneity within the segments: "Students aged 18-25" can be further segmented into subsegments where each subsegment possesses different motivating factors, for example, international students can react better to messaging about gaining confidence in the early stages, while postgraduate students with higher disposable income might like subscription-based offers.

3.2. SMART Objectives using RACE

Using RACE model, two SMART goals have been developed. Goal 1 pertains to the Reach: achieving 500 sessions on the website every month in 90 days through Meta ads and enhanced organic traffic, which will be evaluated through Google Analytics 4 (GA4) Traffic Acquisition reports through filtering through source/medium. The second goal relates to the Engage goal: achieving 15% rate of repeat purchase, where repeat purchase is defined as the second purchase within 30 days after the first purchase, among first-time customers who are acquired in the first 60 days of the launch period and evaluated via GA4 e-commerce purchases. Choosing the Engage goal for Goal 2 is significant from an analytical perspective, repeat purchase, lifetime value, and advocacy are identified as Engage goals which are the key variables related to the retention problem of ByteBite.

3.3. Technique 1: Instagram Meta Ads

The use of Instagram through Meta Ads is based on the Influence Map, which identifies Instagram as a high-influence touchpoint, and the 4S Profile which defines the scrolling as the primary method of content discovery. There are three key rules for efficient Meta Ads: creativity is the new targeting (Andromeda AI of Meta reads the creative for finding the perfect

audience); concept vs. angle (the customer-oriented rationale behind action counts more than the format); one job per ad and alignment to an AIDA stage. The ad created by the group "Shift Finished. Dinner Sorted" with £1.99 first box CTA is done well for the Attention stage. Yet, no creatives for the warm audience retargeting are available. Awareness ladder Cold, Warm and Hot suggests that warm audiences need social proof rather than problem-aware hooks. Student reviews on the product page of ByteBite could be used as such creatives at once using the social proof rule of Cialdini (1984).

However, the more pertinent question is why Instagram became the higher priority platform than TikTok. Although TikTok students were considered the most influential pull channel by the group's Influence Map, it was Instagram that got a paid spend – possibly because of easier creation process and better retargeting through the Meta Pixel. These are all valid considerations; however, the effect is spending money on a medium-level influence channel while considering the high-level influence channel purely organic. One of the greatest strengths of TikTok is its organic virality where a student can spread a video about the ByteBite cooking experience to thousands of other students without any media expense in only 15 minutes.

3.4. Technique 2: Email Marketing

Email has the highest return on investment compared to any other digital marketing tool, although the live strategy has not been set up using email infrastructure. In this case, an alternative retention tool could be SMS, although it has higher opening rates (usually 98%, as opposed to 20% to 30% of email), although it is more intrusive, expensive on a per-message basis, and unable to support the extended Jester narrative that distinguishes the ByteBite messaging style. Email is the correct choice both for ROI and because its format is the only channel capable of extending the brand's storytelling logic beyond the first transaction.

Permission marketing needs explicit permission through opt-in techniques. Setting up a homepage opt-in where the consumer receives a weekly student recipe guide in return for their email will immediately create a retention system. After the customer has made their first purchase, the post-purchase plan will kick off with a Day 1 email with an affective subject line, which gives a 42% higher open rate compared to cognitive subject lines, that would congratulate the customer on their first cook in Jester brand voice and give them a 20% second-order discount code. Next, there is the Day 7 community nurture email that will share a recipe of the week and WhatsApp join link, turning a single purchase customer into a community member. Email analytics, open rate, click-through rate and conversion rate, with Tuesday at 11am as the optimal send time, would track performance against Goal 2: achieving a 15% repeat purchase rate among first-time buyers.

3.5. KPIs and Google Analytics

For Goal 1 (Reach): unique website sessions per month through the GA4 Traffic Acquisition report; and cost per session through Meta Ads in GA4 campaign attribution, helping with budget distribution for cold and warm audience ad sets. For Goal 2 (Engage): 30-day repeat purchase rate through the GA4 e-commerce Purchase report; and click-through rate of the email sent on Day 1 post purchase through GA4 attribution to verify if the communication is leading to the desired follow-up action. The four KPIs above give us a full diagnostic perspective from the first visit to confirmed retention, in accordance with the RACE measurement model.

4. Critical Reflection and Recommendation

4.1. Website Reflection

The ByteBite website uses the index pages architectural pattern where the homepage consists of subpages of equivalent prominence: Shop, Blog & Community, Subscriptions, About & Contact, and How It Works, which are equally balanced between acquisition and retention paths. Site analysis against the four dimensions of online customer experience proposed by Bleier et al. (2019) clearly shows asymmetry. The informativeness is high: transparent pricing, dietary filtering, and product pages with full nutritional data, allergen labelling, and step-by-step instructions. The sensory appeal works because the realistic pictures of the food fit the Everyman archetype's rough character. Social presence is partially done by including names of students in testimonials: Maya, Warwick; Sam, Coventry; Alex, Birmingham; and a Food Hygiene Rating 5 badge, which triggers social proof and authority of Cialdini (1984). Curved call-to-action buttons correspond to Biswas et al.'s (2023) findings that rounded buttons are more efficient than the angular ones. However, entertainment is the least developed dimension and, according to El-Manstrly et al. (2024), it matters more for the total effect on customer loyalty. ByteBite's homepage is functionally efficient but experientially flat: a meaningful gap for a brand whose core problem is making students want to return.

4.2. Recommendations

Four recommendations are prioritised by urgency. First, building email infrastructure: the permission-marketing opt-in homepage followed by the Day 1 and Day 7 post-purchase sequence, later expanded to include abandoned basket and referrals email sequence to those who have placed at least three orders, thereby making loyal customers into brand advocates.

Second, gamification elements as a Student Survival Companion suite that correlates with the academic calendar: Deadline Survival Kit badge, for three consecutive orders in exam term, sets ByteBite apart from its competitors in a manner that price matching does not, illustrating true insight into the needs of a student. A fortnightly community recipe challenge and referrals leaderboard will enable gamification mechanics, which, according to Hollebeek et al., (2019), gamification is a purchase intention, brand loyalty, and word-of-mouth.

Third, the WhatsApp community, while functional, is private and non-discoverable. Migrating to Discord would produce a publicly accessible, Google-indexable community: dedicated channels for recipes, challenges, and voting will result in a live social proof resource available to potential customers at the consideration stage. A natural complement to this community would be a Community Menu Vote approach, which would allow student recommendations for recipes that pass a certain vote count to become a trial ByteBite kit. This operationalises the

co-creation concept, making community participants product creators and thus involving them in the development of the brand.

Fourth, the entertainment gap could be addressed with an AI-based Student Survival Mode feature on the home page by answering three context-based questions ('How much time do you have?', 'What is your energy level?', 'What is going on in this week?') for personalized kit choices based on deadlines, fitness activities, or late lectures. It enables Customization C from the 6Cs model and will help gather data to create personalized emails. As a result, ByteBite will stop being an ordinary ordering platform and will become an engaging one like El-Manstrly et al. (2024) defines.

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